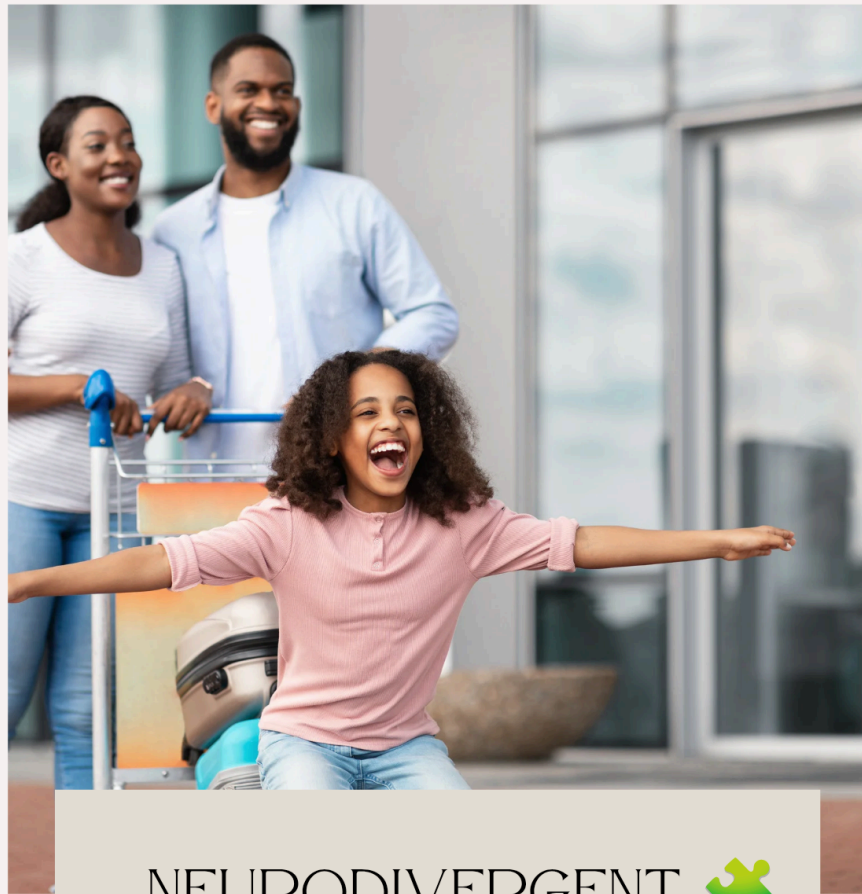




NEURODIVERGENT PEACE ABROAD

A Guide for Neurodivergent
Families Pursuing a peaceful
life Abroad

Neurodivergent Peace Abroad

A Guide for Neurodivergent Families Pursuing Peace Abroad

("You don't need a perfect plan... just a peaceful one.")
By Tashia Monique, Founder of Peace Abroad

Dedication

For every parent who ever felt unseen or unheard... this guide is your permission to build peace, your way.

Mindset Shift: Calibrating for a New World

Before we dive into the logistics of moving abroad, let's pause to recalibrate your mindset. The world you know; what you've been taught, what you've read, what you've been told; is only a small fraction of what actually exists. Many of your perceptions are accurate, but many are not. There is a vast reality beyond the propaganda and beyond systems that condition us to accept less, pay more, do more, and receive less in return.

If there is anyone who truly understands "difference," it is a parent raising a neurodivergent child, or a neurodivergent parent themselves. You already navigate life with patience, adaptation, and perspective as your tools. Now, you get to lean into that gift in a broader context; a new culture, a new society, and a new way of life.

There will be push and pull; give and take; challenges you cannot predict, and rewards you cannot imagine. Because of the battles you've fought for even the smallest things back home, you will find yourself navigating opportunities for giving, sharing, and connecting in ways you may never have imagined.

My greatest advice: be a conduit for new information. Stay curious. Stay open. Allow yourself to expand, grow, and absorb. Learn the rhythm of a new society, embrace its lessons, and above all, be willing to change. The more open you are, the more the world will reveal itself to you.

Letter from the Author

I've been an entrepreneur for over 25 years. I've owned restaurants, catering companies, digital ventures, and brick-and-mortar spaces. I hold four degrees and built my life from the ground up, learning firsthand that entrepreneurship is both art and endurance.

But more than anything, I'm a mother... an AuDHD mother raising a neurodivergent child.

I used to work inside the education system as a K-12 educator. I understand the IEP process, the language schools use, and the pressure parents face to fit their children into frameworks that were never designed for them. I chose a different path.

From the very beginning, I've homeschooled and worldschooled my daughter, creating an educational environment built around curiosity, culture, and compassion instead of rigid standardization. I remain fully compliant with homeschooling laws, but my motivation goes far beyond legal boxes to check... it's about honoring the way my child learns best, not forcing her to adapt to systems that ignore her natural rhythm.

When we moved abroad, I didn't bring the system with me... I brought freedom, structure, and faith in my child's brilliance.

While many of my guides highlight destinations that are particularly affirming for Black families, this one centers the priorities of neurodivergent families first; specifically the needs and well-being of neurodivergent children. That means some of the countries listed here may not have large Black communities or the kind of cultural familiarity you'd find elsewhere. You might be the only Black person in a room... but you'll still be treated with basic humanity and respect.

My goal is not to promise perfection; it's to prepare you for peace. I want you to know what's possible and what's real... so you can choose a place where your child's needs come first, even if the culture isn't yet fluent in diversity.

That's why I built Peace Abroad. It's not about escape. It's about designing a life that actually supports your family's wiring instead of fighting against it. I want you to have the clarity and confidence I wish someone had given me before I took this leap.

Whether you're still dreaming of a move or already packing, remember this: you don't need perfection. You just need a plan that lets you breathe... and a place where your child can thrive.

1. The Realities of Relocating as a Spectrum Parent

Relocating abroad as a neurodivergent parent or with a neurodivergent child requires both courage and clarity.

The Emotional Load: New sensory environments, languages, and routines can be intense for both you and your child.

The Paperwork Reality: You'll need apostilles, background checks, translated documents, and patience for bureaucracy.

The Service Shift: Once you leave the U.S., most formal supports (IEPs, Medicaid, SSI) either disappear or change drastically.

The Tradeoff: You may lose access to certain benefits, but you can often gain stability, safety, and a calmer pace of life.

As a former K-12 educator and current homeschool and worldschool parent, I know firsthand that compliance doesn't always equal alignment. You can follow the law and still build an education that works for your child's needs.

2. Country-by-Country Overview

Below is a snapshot of six countries where neurodivergent families may find varying levels of support, stability, and access to healthcare.

Country Support Level

Cost of Living Visa Pathway Citizenship Feasibility Notes

Canada ★★★★★ Moderate Skilled Worker, PNP, Study ✅ 5 years to citizenship Excellent healthcare and autism support. Strong inclusion in public schools.

Sweden ★★★★★ High Work, Family, EU ✅ 5 years residency World-class healthcare and respect for disability rights; high taxes but high quality of life.

Australia ★★★★★ High Skilled, Employer, Study ✅ 4 years + PR Great services (NDIS) for permanent residents; strong social systems.

Portugal ★★★★★ Moderate D7, Digital Nomad ✅ 5 years residency Calm culture, family-friendly environment, and public healthcare after registration.

Mexico ★★ Low Temporary Resident ⬤ 5 years to permanent Affordable cost of living and private therapy options. Easy visa process.

Albania ★ Very Low Digital Nomad, Residency ⬤ Easy residency, uncertain citizenship Low cost, limited autism infrastructure but safe, simple lifestyle.

Note on Cultural Fit

Every country has its own rhythm and awareness level around race, disability, and inclusion. Some of the safest and most autism-friendly nations may have few Black residents or limited diversity overall. That doesn't always mean they're unwelcoming... it means your presence may be unique, not unsafe.

The goal is to find where your peace and safety overlap... not where you're perfectly understood, but where you and your child are treated with dignity.

3. Pathways by Income Level

Lower-Income Families (\$0–\$2,000/month):

Start in Mexico or Albania. Use this stage to stabilize, homeschool, and lower costs. Save for the next move.

Optional upgrade: If you earn at least €870/month (≈\$950 USD) + 30% per child, you may qualify for Portugal's D7 visa.

Example: A single parent with one child needs roughly €1,130/month (≈\$1,230 USD) in provable, stable income.

You'll also need to show savings covering 12 months of living expenses, proof of housing, and clean background checks.

Middle-Income Families (\$2,000–\$3,500/month):

Apply for Portugal's D7 visa directly from the U.S. Prepare proof of income, apostilles, and background checks.

Upper-Middle Income Families (\$3,500–\$6,000/month):

Pursue skilled worker visas in Canada or Australia. These provide structured healthcare and paths to citizenship.

4. Employment First, Entrepreneurship Second

Entrepreneurship abroad can work... but it's not for everyone. Parents of neurodivergent children already carry a heavy emotional and logistical load. Trying to build a business while adapting to a new country can be overwhelming.

I say this as someone who has owned multiple businesses; restaurants, catering companies, and digital ventures for over two decades. Entrepreneurship is a calling, not a shortcut. It can bring freedom... but it can also bring famine.

If you're already managing a child's needs and your own stability, adding business stress can break you before it frees you. That's why I recommend stability first: employment, healthcare, and a safe home... and creation second.

5. Why Employment Abroad Might Be the Smartest Path

Most families should stabilize through traditional employment, remote or local (work visa), because employment visas often include healthcare, social security contributions, and a clear path to residency or citizenship.

The internet sells the fantasy of “expat living” or “digital nomad freedom,” but the truth is... you can live beautifully and securely as a resident, not a perpetual tourist. You don’t need to chase a luxury lifestyle to build a peaceful one. You can work, pay taxes, integrate, and still create a life abroad that honors both your child’s needs and your own well-being.

6a. U.S. Benefits Abroad: SSI vs SSDI Program

What It Is...

Can You Keep It Abroad?

Key Details

SSDI Earned benefit from your or your spouse’s/parent’s work history.

✔ Yes Continues abroad in most countries except Cuba & North Korea. Must file SSA-21 and annual proof-of-life forms.

SSI Needs-based welfare benefit.

✘ No Stops after 30 days outside the U.S.; restarts only after 30 consecutive days back in the U.S.

Families living abroad on disability income are almost always on SSDI, not SSI. Plan accordingly.

6b. Healthcare & Insurance (*Before Residency*)

Before you gain residency or citizenship, you’re not yet covered by the local public health system. Which means you’ll need private international health insurance for your visa approval and early months abroad.

Here’s what that looks like in practice:

Portugal: Proof of private health insurance valid in the EU is mandatory for your D7 or other long-stay visa. Most expats use companies like Cigna, Allianz, or SafetyWing until they receive residency and can enroll in the SNS (Serviço Nacional de Saúde) system. (Cont'd)

Mexico: You can enter on a tourist visa without coverage, but you'll pay out of pocket for all care. Once you apply for temporary residency, private insurance (AXA, IMG, etc.) is recommended until you qualify for IMSS public healthcare.

Albania & other low-cost destinations: Expect to use private clinics. International or regional expat insurance is often required if you plan to extend or apply for residency.

 **Pro Tip:** Choose a plan that covers:

Emergency and hospital visits abroad

Autism-related therapies (speech, OT, behavioral)

Medication refill coverage internationally

 **Note:** Once residency is granted, you can apply for public health coverage in that country... but keep private insurance active until your local policy is confirmed and functional.

Medication Caution for Neurodivergent Families

If your child (or you) take prescription medications such as Adderall, Ritalin, or other controlled stimulants, research the official government regulations in your destination... not hearsay in expat groups.

Example: In Mexico, Adderall (amphetamine salts) is not legally available through pharmacies or prescription. Any product sold as "Adderall" on the street or online is likely counterfeit or adulterated, meaning it could contain unsafe or unverified substances.

Some countries classify ADHD medications as narcotics or controlled substances, requiring import permits or prohibiting them entirely.

Always travel with a doctor's letter, original packaging, and a translated prescription list if carrying medication internationally.

 **Bottom Line:** Before moving, check every medication: dosage, ingredient, and legal status in your target country. Do not assume equivalents exist or that you can refill prescriptions easily abroad.

7. The Peace Abroad Stair-Step Framework for Quick Exit (if 🦌 hits the fan)

1. **Stabilize** — Choose an affordable country (Mexico, Panama, Albania). Rebuild structure and peace. These may be soft landing locations in the event that you have to leave quickly and need somewhere to go.
2. **Secure** — Obtain remote or local employment; gather documents for your next visa or preferably a residency.
3. **Sustain** — Transition to a healthcare-strong nation like Portugal or Canada.
4. **Settle** — After 4–5 years of residency, apply for citizenship and long-term healthcare access.

🔔 Important Reminder:

Before you even make the final decision to move, start gathering all critical documents now and keep them in one secure place — ideally both physical and digital.

In the event of an emergency or sudden relocation opportunity, you'll save yourself weeks of stress and unnecessary expenses.

It can be costly and complicated to request official records (like birth certificates, medical files, or school transcripts) once you're outside the U.S., and processing times abroad are often unpredictable.

Create a simple "Go Folder" or Go Bag with:

- Passports and birth certificates
- Medical records and therapy reports
- Educational or homeschool documentation
- Custody or guardianship papers (if applicable)
- Proof of income and financial documents
- Copies of prescriptions and diagnoses

💡 This is one of the smartest first steps you can take as a neurodivergent parent considering a move abroad... preparation now saves overwhelm later.

8. Common Questions from Parents

Q: If I keep my U.S. address but live abroad, do I still lose SSI?

A: Yes. SSI is based on physical presence, not mailing address. After 30 days abroad, payments stop.

Q: Can I keep SSDI if I become a legal resident elsewhere?

A: Yes. SSDI continues as long as you report your address and complete annual verification forms.

Q: Can SSDI count as income for visa applications?

A: Yes. SSDI qualifies as proof of consistent income for visas like Portugal's D7 or Mexico's residency.

Q: Why not just live like an expat or nomad?

A: Because legal residency and local integration offer stability, healthcare, and long-term peace that short-term visas do not.

9. Closing Message

This guide isn't meant to scare you... it's meant to steady you.

You deserve to live in a place where your child can thrive and you can breathe again. Peace isn't found by running; it's found by planning. Whether that peace begins in Mexico, Portugal, or Canada... you'll know when you've found it, because it will finally feel like home.

About the Author

Tashia Monique is a neurodivergent entrepreneur, educator, and author who has lived, worked, and homeschooled abroad with her daughter for years. She is the founder of Peace Abroad, a global education and lifestyle brand dedicated to helping families build freedom and peace beyond borders.